Bharat Mata: The Voice of Every Indian[1]

Rahul Gandhi

‘If words come from the heart, they will enter the heart.’

—Rumi

Last year, I spent 145 days walking across the land I call home. I started at the edge of the sea and walked through heat, dust and rain, through forests, towns and hills, until I reached the soft snow of my beloved Kashmir. Many people along the way asked me: Why are you doing this? Even today they ask: Why? What were you looking for? What did you find?

I wanted to understand the thing I loved. The thing for which I was ready to give up everything, including my life. The thing that could make me take so much pain and abuse for so many years.

I wanted to know precisely what it was that I loved. Was it this land? The mountains? The sea? Was it a person? Was it a people, or a set of ideas? But there was something else. I also wanted to understand what sort of heart was mine that had allowed itself to be captured in this way.

For years I used to run 8 to 10 kilometres every evening. So I thought, ‘Twenty-five? I can easily walk 25 kilometres.’ I was certain the walk was going to be easy.